



IN CONTEXT

GENRE

Comedy drama

DIRECTOR

Pedro Almodóvar

WRITER

Pedro Almodóvar

STARS

Carmen Maura, Antonio Banderas, Julieta Serrano, María Barranco

BEFORE

1980 Almodóvar makes his ultra low-budget, playfully outrageous debut with *Pepi, Luci, Bom, and Other Girls Like Mom*.

AFTER

1999 *All About My Mother*, one of Almodóvar's best, brings all his themes to the boil.

2002 Almodóvar's *Talk to Her* is a controversial, highly charged romantic thriller about two men caring for two women, both of whom are in a coma.

I THOUGHT THIS ONLY HAPPENED IN THE MOVIES

WOMEN ON THE VERGE OF A NERVOUS BREAKDOWN / 1988

Women on the Verge of a Nervous Breakdown (*Mujeres al borde de un ataque de nervios*) is the story of Pepa (Carmen Maura), a Spanish actress who dubs the voices of US movies with her faithless boyfriend, Iván (Fernando Guillén). Their relationship is not so much a love story as a door-slamming farce.

Panic attack

It's perhaps appropriate that the meaning of the movie's title gets lost in translation. The *ataques de nervios* of the Spanish title refers to a panic attack, a state of breathlessness that director Pedro Almodóvar sustains at a madcap pace inspired by the Hollywood "screwball" comedies of

the 1940s. It looks to the past, but the movie's comedy is also thrillingly contemporary. Post-Franco Madrid is the perfect setting for its manic farce, with Almodóvar whipping up subplots involving Arab terrorists, dance-crazy cab drivers, and soup spiked with sleeping pills. Yet the boisterous stuff is shot through with the director's trademark sense of humanity. ■

At Pepa's

apartment, a suicidal Candela (María Barranco) is distracted by Carlos (Antonio Banderas).



What else to watch: *Matador* (1986) ■ *Tie Me Up! Tie Me Down!* (1989) ■ *High Heels* (1991) ■ *Live Flesh* (1997) ■ *Volver* (2006) ■ *The Skin I Live In* (2011)